

More than just screens

What social media really means to us

Last Tuesday evening, I was waiting for the bus by the market square when an elderly lady from my street asked if I could help her with her phone. She looked genuinely worried that she had “broken something”. In reality, she was trying to find photos of her granddaughter’s birthday that had been shared on Facebook. Of course I wanted to help, and a few taps later, she was smiling — and showing me a picture of a cake with far too many candles on it.

I’m a local student, and like most people my age, social media has always been part of my life. It’s easy to forget that for many people in our community, it’s something they’ve had to learn later on. That gap often explains the very different attitudes towards social media: for young people, it’s a normal way to communicate and stay connected; for older generations and schools, it can feel unfamiliar, distracting, or even risky.

There are real problems, and it would be dishonest to ignore them. Social media can be addictive, and it can make people feel judged or left out. I’ve seen friends compare themselves to the carefully edited lives they see online and end up feeling worse about their own. Schools worry about bullying, screen time, and attention spans — and those concerns are reasonable. But if we only talk about the dangers, we miss the full picture.

During the pandemic, my grandmother learned to use WhatsApp so she could speak to her sister every Sunday evening. They live hundreds of miles apart, and before that, they rarely stayed in touch. Now it’s a routine they both value. Locally, community groups use social media to share lost pets, organise charity events, and check in on neighbours who might be struggling. These aren’t influencers or trends — just ordinary people using technology to make life a little easier.

Perhaps the issue isn’t whether social media is good or bad, but how we choose to use it. Young people need guidance rather than constant criticism. The older generation deserve patience and support. And schools ought to accept that social media is not something to be banned out of existence, but understood and managed.

Social media is a shared space. Like our own town centre, it can be loud, messy, and frustrating — but it can also bring people together. Used carefully, it doesn’t replace real life; it supports it. And that is something worth recognising.